

Olympiad Test Paper — Social Science (Class 7)

Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries

Subject	Social Science (NCERT Class 7)
Chapter	15 — Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries
Total Questions	60 (Multiple Choice, single correct)
Maximum Marks	240
Suggested Time	90 minutes

Marking scheme: +4 for each correct answer · -1 for each wrong answer · 0 if unattempted.

Instructions: Each question has four options (A), (B), (C), (D); exactly one is correct. Watch the classic traps: the post-Gupta age was CREATIVE (temples, universities, the rules of zero, Bhakti), not a 'dark age'; the Arabs conquered only SINDH in 712 CE and were held to a small foothold, not most of India; the caste (jati) system was FLEXIBLE, not rigid; a king ruled through LAYERS (samantas and self-governing village sabhas), not directly over every village; and a traveller's account (Xuanzang) is ONE source to cross-check. Match dynasties to their monuments (Rashtrakutas-Ellora, Pallavas-Mamallapuram, Palas-Nalanda). Do not write on this paper — mark answers on your answer sheet.

1. From about 600 CE to 1200 CE, India:

- (A) had no single empire but many strong regional kingdoms
- (B) was ruled by one vast empire across the whole subcontinent
- (C) had no kingdoms at all
- (D) was ruled entirely by the Arabs

2. The chapter argues that the period after the Guptas was:

- (A) a 'dark age' with nothing happening
- (B) a time with no art or learning
- (C) an age ruled by a single emperor
- (D) a creative age of temples, universities and new ideas, not a decline

3. The claim 'the period after the Guptas was a dark age with nothing happening' is wrong because it saw:

- (A) no building, learning or religion of any kind
- (B) only constant defeat by foreigners
- (C) the complete end of Indian culture
- (D) great temples, universities, the rules of zero and the Bhakti tradition

4. 'No single empire but many kingdoms' best describes a period of:

- (A) total political unity
- (B) political fragmentation alongside cultural flourishing
- (C) complete cultural collapse
- (D) foreign rule over all of India

5. Harshavardhana, the north's last great king of this age, ruled from:

- (A) Vatapi
- (B) Kanchi
- (C) Ellora
- (D) Kannauj

6. Harshavardhana came to power around:

- (A) 1206 CE
- (B) 326 BCE
- (C) 606 CE
- (D) 1947 CE

7. After Harshavardhana, the north had:

- (A) no single dominant emperor, leading to a contest among regional powers
- (B) one unchallenged emperor for centuries
- (C) no rulers at all
- (D) permanent Arab rule

8. Xuanzang, who described Harsha's India, was a:

- (A) Chinese pilgrim who travelled across India
- (B) Pala king of Bengal
- (C) Arab general
- (D) Tamil Bhakti saint

9. The chapter warns that a traveller's account like Xuanzang's should be treated as:

- (A) a perfect and complete record needing no checking
- (B) completely worthless
- (C) the only source historians may use
- (D) one valuable source, to be cross-checked against inscriptions, coins and local records

10. 'Epigraphy' is the study of:

- (A) coins and currency
- (B) the stars and planets
- (C) inscriptions carved on stone or metal
- (D) old travelogues only

11. A 'prashasti' inscription must be read carefully by historians because it:

- (A) is always completely neutral and exact
- (B) was written by the king's enemies
- (C) praises a ruler and can exaggerate his achievements
- (D) records only ordinary village life

12. The 'Tripartite Struggle' was a long contest among three powers for control of:

- (A) Ellora
- (B) the Tamil south
- (C) Sindh
- (D) Kannauj

13. The three powers in the Tripartite Struggle were the:

- (A) Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras
- (B) Chalukyas, Pallavas and Guptas
- (C) Mauryas, Shungas and Satavahanas
- (D) Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas

- 14.** The Tripartite Struggle shows that, in this age, Kannauj was seen as:
(A) a prized symbol of supremacy over the north
(B) a worthless, ignored town (C) a southern port city
(D) an Arab capital
- 15.** That three powers fought for so long without one winning permanently shows the age was one of:
(A) a single unbeatable empire (B) total peace with no rivalry
(C) foreign rule over all the north
(D) balanced rivalry among strong regional kingdoms
- 16.** The Palas ruled mainly in:
(A) the Tamil south (B) the Deccan plateau
(C) Kashmir (D) Bengal
- 17.** The Palas are especially remembered for supporting:
(A) the stone temples of Mamallapuram
(B) great Buddhist universities like Nalanda and Vikramashila
(C) the Kailasa temple at Ellora (D) the Arab conquest of Sindh
- 18.** A 'dvarapandita' at Vikramashila was a:
(A) 'scholar gatekeeper' who tested students before admission
(B) subordinate ruler paying tribute (C) chariot-shaped temple
(D) village assembly
- 19.** That Vikramashila tested students through a dvarapandita shows its universities:
(A) admitted no students at all (B) maintained high standards of learning
(C) taught nothing useful (D) were really army camps
- 20.** The Gurjara-Pratiharas are described as the:
(A) rulers of the Tamil far south (B) defenders of the north-west
(C) builders of Ellora (D) kings of Bengal
- 21.** By holding the north-west, the Gurjara-Pratiharas helped:
(A) invite the Arabs to conquer all India (B) limit the Arab advance beyond Sindh
(C) end the Tripartite Struggle peacefully (D) build the temples of Mamallapuram
- 22.** The Rashtrakutas are linked to the wonder of:
(A) Ellora (B) Mamallapuram
(C) Nalanda (D) Kannauj alone
- 23.** The Kailasa temple at Ellora is remarkable because it is:
(A) built of paper (B) made of digital screens
(C) monolithic - carved from a single block of rock
(D) assembled from imported bricks

24. 'Monolithic' means:

- (A) built from thousands of small bricks (B) made of wood and cloth
- (C) made from a single block of stone or rock (D) constructed entirely underwater

25. Carving an entire temple from one rock, as at Ellora, shows the age's:

- (A) lack of any artistic ability (B) complete cultural decline
- (C) dependence on foreign builders (D) extraordinary skill in art and engineering

26. The Chalukyas of this age had their base at:

- (A) Vatapi (B) Kannauj
- (C) Bengal (D) Sindh

27. The Chalukyas, Pallavas and reviving Cholas built mainly:

- (A) Buddhist universities in Bengal
- (B) great temples and trade networks in the south and Deccan
- (C) the Kailasa temple at Ellora (D) an Arab state in Sindh

28. The Pallavas ruled from Kanchi and are famous for the stone temples of:

- (A) Ellora (B) Nalanda
- (C) Vatapi (D) Mamallapuram

29. A 'ratha', as carved at Mamallapuram, is:

- (A) a village assembly (B) a subordinate ruler
- (C) a man-made reservoir
- (D) a temple or shrine carved to look like a chariot

30. The rock-cut rathas of Mamallapuram are evidence of the Pallavas':

- (A) skill in paper-making (B) control of the Silk Route
- (C) rule over Bengal (D) mastery of stone temple art

31. Both Ellora's Kailasa temple and Mamallapuram's rathas show that this age excelled at:

- (A) printing books on paper (B) carving temples directly from rock
- (C) minting paper money (D) building with steel

32. In the south, alongside the Chalukyas and Pallavas, which ancient dynasties revived in this age?

- (A) the Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas (B) the Mauryas, Shungas and Guptas
- (C) the Hunas, Shakas and Kushanas (D) the Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras

33. The revival of the Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras shows that the Tamil south was:

- (A) again a centre of strong kingdoms, temples and trade
- (B) empty of any kingdoms (C) ruled entirely by the Arabs
- (D) part of the Pala empire of Bengal

- 34.** A 'samanta' was a:
- (A) subordinate ruler through whom a king governed outer regions, in return for tribute and soldiers
 - (B) Tamil poet-saint
 - (C) chariot-shaped temple
 - (D) Chinese pilgrim
- 35.** The claim 'a king of this age personally ran every part of his kingdom' is wrong because he ruled through:
- (A) no officials at all
 - (B) layers of samantas and largely self-governing villages
 - (C) only foreign Arab governors
 - (D) a single nationwide election
- 36.** A 'sabha' was a:
- (A) single all-powerful emperor
 - (B) chariot-shaped temple
 - (C) village assembly
 - (D) Buddhist university
- 37.** The Chola Uttaramerur inscriptions are valuable because they describe:
- (A) how to carve a monolithic temple
 - (B) the rules of zero
 - (C) how members of the village sabha were selected
 - (D) the Arab conquest of Sindh
- 38.** That villages governed themselves through a sabha shows this age had:
- (A) no government below the king
 - (B) rule only by foreign powers
 - (C) a single national parliament
 - (D) real local self-government beneath the kings
- 39.** Royal power in this age is best described as flowing:
- (A) directly from the king to each individual villager
 - (B) only from foreign Arab rulers
 - (C) down through many hands - samantas and village assemblies - not straight from king to every villager
 - (D) from a single elected president
- 40.** A 'land grant' in this age:
- (A) gave land to a person, community or temple, creating a class of landholders
 - (B) took all land away from everyone
 - (C) was a chariot-shaped temple
 - (D) was a Tamil devotional poem
- 41.** A 'tank' (eri in Tamil) was a:
- (A) war chariot
 - (B) large man-made reservoir storing rainwater for irrigation and daily use
 - (C) Buddhist monastery
 - (D) subordinate ruler
- 42.** Merchant guilds and busy towns in this age show that the economy was:

- (A) completely destroyed (B) thriving, not collapsing
(C) based only on barter with no trade (D) controlled entirely by the Arabs

43. Land grants, guilds and tanks together show that this age combined:

- (A) total economic ruin (B) a complete lack of trade
(C) a productive economy with careful management of land and water
(D) rule with no landholders at all

44. The claim 'the caste (varna-jati) system was completely rigid and fixed' is wrong because:

- (A) caste never changed for anyone, anywhere (B) there were no jatis at all
(C) it was flexible and varied by region - for example, the Palas rose from Shudra to Kshatriya status
(D) everyone belonged to one single group

45. The Kayasthas are given as an example of how:

- (A) a jati could never change (B) foreigners ruled all India
(C) a profession could turn into a jati over time (D) temples were carved from rock

46. That jatis multiplied and some families changed status shows the social system was:

- (A) complex and changing, not frozen (B) perfectly simple and unchanging
(C) abolished completely (D) identical everywhere in India

47. The chapter notes that, in this age, some women and queens:

- (A) were entirely absent from public life (B) ruled the whole subcontinent alone
(C) held real influence and power (D) were forbidden from any role

48. The 'Bhakti' tradition began in the:

- (A) Central Asian steppe (B) Arab lands of Sindh
(C) Himalayan north alone (D) Tamil south

49. 'Bhakti' means:

- (A) personal, loving devotion to a deity, open to all
(B) a war between three kingdoms (C) a tax paid to a king
(D) the study of inscriptions

50. Bhakti differed from older Vedic practice by being:

- (A) open to all, through personal devotion rather than only formal sacrifice
(B) closed to everyone except kings (C) based only on grand sacrifices
(D) a foreign Arab religion

51. The 'Alvars' were:

- (A) the sixty-three poet-saints devoted to Shiva
(B) the twelve Tamil poet-saints devoted to Vishnu
(C) subordinate rulers paying tribute (D) village assemblies

- 52.** The 'Nayanars' were:
- (A) the twelve poet-saints devoted to Vishnu
 - (B) Chinese pilgrims
 - (C) the sixty-three Tamil poet-saints devoted to Shiva
 - (D) Arab generals
- 53.** The mathematician of this age who gave the world the rules of zero was:
- (A) Brahmagupta
 - (B) Harshavardhana
 - (C) Xuanzang
 - (D) Kalhana
- 54.** The 'Rajatarangini', a rare ancient Indian work of formal history, was:
- (A) a treatise on the rules of zero
 - (B) Kalhana's 12th-century epic recording the history of Kashmir's dynasties
 - (C) a Tamil devotional poem
 - (D) an Arab account of Sindh
- 55.** A 'chronicle' is:
- (A) a chariot-shaped temple
 - (B) a written record of events set down in the order they happened
 - (C) a reservoir for water
 - (D) a subordinate ruler
- 56.** The Arabs first conquered which part of the subcontinent, in 712 CE?
- (A) the whole of India
 - (B) Sindh
 - (C) the Tamil south
 - (D) Bengal
- 57.** The claim 'the Arabs conquered most of India in 712 CE' is wrong because:
- (A) they conquered the entire subcontinent
 - (B) they never reached India at all
 - (C) they took only Sindh, and Arab rule stayed confined to a small foothold for centuries
 - (D) they ruled India until 1947
- 58.** Arab expansion beyond Sindh was held back largely by:
- (A) a complete lack of any Indian resistance
 - (B) the Arabs' own decision to leave
 - (C) Indian rulers like the Gurjara-Pratiharas and Kashmir's Lalitaditya
 - (D) the Chinese army
- 59.** That the Arabs were repulsed from 637 CE and then confined after 712 CE shows:
- (A) India offered no resistance at all
 - (B) strong Indian resistance limited the foreign advance
 - (C) the Arabs easily took everything
 - (D) there were no Arab attempts on India
- 60.** A student says, 'After the Guptas India fell into a dark age, the Arabs conquered most of it in 712, and caste was completely rigid.' The best correction is:
- (A) it was a creative age of kingdoms and temples, the Arabs took only Sindh, and the caste system was flexible
 - (B) all three statements are correct

(C) India had no kingdoms and the Arabs ruled everything

(D) caste was rigid but the age was otherwise creative

Solutions — Social Science (Class 7), Chapter 15: Empires and Kingdoms: 6th to 10th Centuries

Marking: +4 correct, –1 wrong, 0 unattempted. Maximum marks **240**.

Answer Key

Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans	Q	Ans
1	A	11	C	21	B	31	B	41	B	51	B
2	D	12	D	22	A	32	D	42	B	52	C
3	D	13	D	23	C	33	A	43	C	53	A
4	B	14	A	24	C	34	A	44	C	54	B
5	D	15	D	25	D	35	B	45	C	55	B
6	C	16	D	26	A	36	C	46	A	56	B
7	A	17	B	27	B	37	C	47	C	57	C
8	A	18	A	28	D	38	D	48	D	58	C
9	D	19	B	29	D	39	C	49	A	59	B
10	C	20	B	30	D	40	A	50	A	60	A

Answer-key distribution: A = 15, B = 15, C = 15, D = 15.

Worked Solutions

- (A)** After the Guptas faded, India had many strong regional kingdoms rather than one empire. It was not one empire, kingdom-less, or Arab-ruled.
- (D)** It was a vibrant, creative age (Ellora, Mamallapuram, universities, the rules of zero, Bhakti), not a dark age or single-emperor era.
- (D)** The age produced Ellora, Mamallapuram, Nalanda and Vikramashila, the rules of zero and Bhakti - creativity, not a void.
- (B)** Many regional kingdoms meant political fragmentation, yet culture flourished. It was not unity, collapse, or all-India foreign rule.
- (D)** Harshavardhana ruled from Kannauj (from 606 CE). Vatapi was the Chalukya capital, Kanchi the Pallava capital, and Ellora a Rashtrakuta temple site.
- (C)** Harshavardhana came to power around 606 CE. 1206 is far later, 326 BCE is Alexander's time, and 1947 is independence.

- 7. (A)** After Harsha, no single emperor dominated the north, sparking the Tripartite Struggle among regional powers. It was not one emperor, ruler-less, or Arab-ruled.
- 8. (A)** Xuanzang was a Chinese Buddhist pilgrim who toured India. He was not a Pala king, an Arab general, or a Bhakti saint.
- 9. (D)** A traveller writes from his own viewpoint and may exaggerate, so his account is one source to cross-check. It is neither perfect, worthless, nor the only source.
- 10. (C)** Epigraphy (Greek *epi-* 'on' + *graphein* 'to write') studies inscriptions on stone or metal. Coins are numismatics, stars are astronomy, and travelogues are one source among many.
- 11. (C)** A *prashasti* is a eulogy praising a ruler and may exaggerate, so it needs careful handling. It is not neutral, enemy-written, or about ordinary village life.
- 12. (D)** The Tripartite Struggle was for Kannauj, the symbolic key to the north. Ellora was a temple site, the Tamil south had its own kingdoms, and Sindh was taken by the Arabs.
- 13. (D)** The Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas fought the Tripartite Struggle. The southern trio, the Chalukya/Pallava/Gupta set, and the ancient dynasties are different.
- 14. (A)** Three great powers fighting for Kannauj shows it was a prized symbol of northern supremacy. It was not worthless, southern, or Arab.
- 15. (D)** A long, indecisive three-way struggle reflects balanced rivalry among strong kingdoms. It was not one empire, peaceful, or foreign-ruled.
- 16. (D)** The Palas ruled Bengal (and the east). The Tamil south, Deccan and Kashmir belonged to other powers.
- 17. (B)** The Palas patronised Buddhist universities such as Nalanda and Vikramashila. Mamallapuram was Pallava, Ellora Rashtrakuta, and the Sindh conquest Arab.
- 18. (A)** A *dvarapandita* was a scholar-gatekeeper testing students for admission at Vikramashila. A tribute-paying ruler is a *samanta*, a chariot-temple a *ratha*, and a village assembly a *sabha*.
- 19. (B)** Testing entrants through a scholar-gatekeeper shows high academic standards. The universities did admit students, taught valuable subjects, and were centres of learning, not army camps.
- 20. (B)** The Gurjara-Pratiharas defended the north-west (notably against the Arabs). The Tamil south, Ellora and Bengal belonged to other powers.

- 21. (B)** The Gurjara-Pratiharas helped confine the Arabs to a small foothold. They did not invite conquest, peacefully end the struggle, or build Mamallapuram.
- 22. (A)** The Rashtrakutas are linked to Ellora's great rock-cut temple. Mamallapuram is Pallava, Nalanda Pala, and Kannauj the prize of the Tripartite Struggle.
- 23. (C)** The Kailasa temple is monolithic, carved from one mass of rock. It is not paper, digital, or imported brick.
- 24. (C)** Monolithic means from a single block of stone. Brick, wood-and-cloth and underwater construction are different.
- 25. (D)** A monolithic temple shows extraordinary artistic and engineering skill - evidence the age was creative. It is not a sign of no ability, decline, or foreign dependence.
- 26. (A)** The Chalukyas ruled from Vatapi in the Deccan. Kannauj, Bengal and Sindh belonged to other powers.
- 27. (B)** The southern and Deccan powers built great temples and trade networks. Bengal's universities were Pala, Ellora Rashtrakuta, and Sindh's state Arab.
- 28. (D)** The Pallavas of Kanchi built the stone temples of Mamallapuram. Ellora is Rashtrakuta, Nalanda Pala, and Vatapi Chalukya.
- 29. (D)** A ratha (Sanskrit 'chariot') is a chariot-shaped shrine, as at Mamallapuram. A village assembly is a sabha, a subordinate ruler a samanta, and a reservoir a tank.
- 30. (D)** The rathas show Pallava mastery of stone temple art. They are not about paper, the Silk Route, or Bengal.
- 31. (B)** Both are rock-cut wonders, showing the age's skill in carving temples from stone. Paper printing, paper money and steel building are unrelated.
- 32. (D)** The Cholas, Pandyas and Cheras revived in the south. The Tripartite trio ruled the north, and the others are earlier dynasties or invaders.
- 33. (A)** Their revival made the Tamil south a hub of kingdoms, temples and trade once more. It was not empty, Arab-ruled, or Pala-ruled.
- 34. (A)** A samanta was a subordinate ruler (vassal) governing outer regions for a king, giving tribute and soldiers. A poet-saint is an Alvar or Nayanar, a chariot-temple a ratha, and a pilgrim like Xuanzang.
- 35. (B)** Kings ruled through subordinate samantas and self-governing villages, not directly over every village. There were officials, not Arab governors or national elections.

- 36. (C)** A sabha was a village assembly through which villages governed themselves. It was not an emperor, a ratha, or a university.
- 37. (C)** The Uttaramerur inscriptions record how village sabha members were chosen - evidence of local self-rule. They are not about temple-carving, zero, or Sindh.
- 38. (D)** Self-governing village sabhas show genuine local self-rule under the kings. There was government below the king, it was not foreign-only, and there was no national parliament.
- 39. (C)** Power passed down through samantas and sabhas rather than directly from king to villager. It was not direct, Arab-only, or presidential.
- 40. (A)** Land grants gave land to people, communities or temples, creating landholders. They did not seize land, and they were not rathas or poems.
- 41. (B)** A tank (eri) was a man-made reservoir for water storage and irrigation. It was not a chariot, a monastery, or a samanta.
- 42. (B)** Merchant guilds and flourishing towns show a thriving economy. It was not destroyed, barter-only, or Arab-controlled.
- 43. (C)** Land grants, guilds and water tanks reflect a productive, well-managed economy. It was not ruined, trade-free, or landholder-free.
- 44. (C)** The system was flexible: the Palas rose in status and professions like the Kayasthas became jatis. It was not unchanging, jati-free, or single-group.
- 45. (C)** The Kayasthas show a profession becoming a jati over time - evidence of flexibility. It is not about unchanging jatis, foreign rule, or temple-carving.
- 46. (A)** Multiplying jatis and status changes show a complex, changing system. It was not frozen, abolished, or identical everywhere.
- 47. (C)** Some women and queens held real influence. They were not wholly absent, sole rulers of all India, or barred from every role.
- 48. (D)** Bhakti began in the Tamil south. It did not start on the steppe, in Arab Sindh, or only in the Himalayan north.
- 49. (A)** Bhakti (Sanskrit bhaj, 'to be devoted') is personal, loving devotion to a deity, open to everyone. It is not a war, a tax, or epigraphy.
- 50. (A)** Bhakti opened devotion to all through personal love of a deity, rather than only formal Vedic sacrifice. It was not king-only, sacrifice-only, or Arab.

- 51. (B)** The Alvars were the twelve Tamil poet-saints of Vishnu. The Shiva poet-saints are the Nayanars, tribute-payers are samantas, and assemblies are sabhas.
- 52. (C)** The Nayanars were the sixty-three Tamil poet-saints of Shiva. The twelve Vishnu poet-saints are the Alvars; Xuanzang was a pilgrim, not a Nayanar.
- 53. (A)** Brahmagupta gave the rules for calculating with zero. Harshavardhana was a king, Xuanzang a pilgrim, and Kalhana a historian.
- 54. (B)** The Rajatarangini is Kalhana's 12th-century history of Kashmir's dynasties. It is not a maths treatise, a Bhakti poem, or an Arab chronicle.
- 55. (B)** A chronicle (Greek chronos, 'time') records events in time order. A chariot-temple is a ratha, a reservoir a tank, and a subordinate ruler a samanta.
- 56. (B)** The Arabs conquered Sindh in 712 CE. They did not take all of India, the Tamil south, or Bengal.
- 57. (C)** The Arabs took only Sindh, and their rule stayed limited to a small foothold (Sindh and part of Punjab). They did not conquer all India, nor were they absent, nor did they rule to 1947.
- 58. (C)** Indian rulers such as the Gurjara-Pratiharas and Lalitaditya resisted, confining the Arabs. It was not for lack of resistance, an Arab choice, or Chinese help.
- 59. (B)** Being repulsed and then confined shows strong Indian resistance limited the Arab advance. There was resistance, the Arabs did not take everything, and they did attempt expansion.
- 60. (A)** The post-Gupta age was creative, the Arabs took only Sindh, and caste was flexible - correcting all three errors. The other options keep one or more misconceptions.